SHUTTERSTOCK



Shivamogga, Karnataka

Forests, rivers, ancient temples, this region has it all. Best visited during the monsoon, it is known for its many majestic waterfalls. Like the Jog Falls, India's third highest, and the terrace-like Dabbe Falls that are located inside the Sharavati Wildlife Sanctuary. Trekkers will also enjoy the challenge of the 6-km trek from Hegganur to see the Unchalli or Lushington Falls. The Linganamakki Dam, which straddles the Sharavati River, the temple at Sigandur which is dedicated to Chowdamma Devi, the goddess who protects people from thieves, and the Kanoor Fort, also known as 'Keladi Kote', are interesting stops. There's kayaking and river rafting to be had in the town of Honnemaradu, and a chance to see the big cats from circuses rehabilitated in the wild at the 200-hectare Tyavarekoppa Lion and Tiger Reserve.

DO
About 64 km away is Gokarna, on the Karwar coast, which is popular through the year but can also be the ideal vacay you saved for a rainy day. Enjoy the laidback vibe of Om Beach and Kudle Beach as the monsoon works its magic

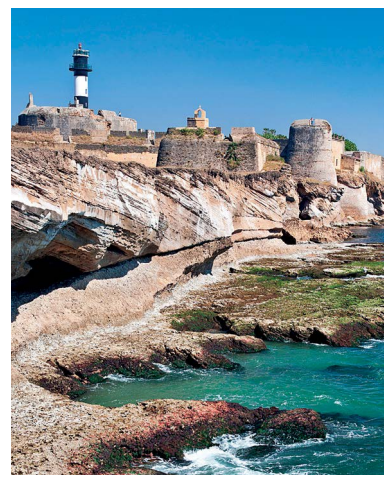
STAY
Gabadi River Edge Resort

EAT
Steamed paddu and various types of dosai at Sri Meenakshi Bhawan

GO
Fly to Mangaluru and drive 165 km

Diu

While its breathtaking beaches such as Nagoa, Ghogla, Chakratirth, etc., may not be the best choice if there's heavy rain, Diu has many other points of interest. Explore the surreal maze of the Naida caves. Visit the Diu Fort, the Diu Museum inside St Thomas Church, *shivlings* at the Gangeshwar Mahadev temple (which are often hidden by the high tide), the Zampa Gateway, the St Paul's Church and even a sea shell museum.



INDIA PICTURE

DO The 16th-century Panikota Fort, rising like 'The Rock' in the middle of the sea was once Diu jail. A rainy-day boat ride to this Fortim do Mar can be quite an adventure. Don't miss the chapel and lighthouse nearby

EAT Portuguese seafood specialities like curries made with coconut or tamarind at the family-run O Coqueiro

STAY The Fern Seaside Luxurious Tent Resort or Kostamar Beach Resort

GO Well-connected by air

CLEAR ESCAPE

Spiti, Himachal Pradesh

If you want nothing to do with the monsoon, head to Spiti, which gets next to no rain around the year. There's plenty of sunshine, but perhaps you'd prefer to undertake a trek to a glacier lake like Chandra Taal, or head to the passes like Hampta, Kunzum or Baralacha. Meditate at Buddhist monasteries, seek snow leopard sightings at Pin Valley National Park, climb to Giu near Tabo to see the 500-year-old mummy of a Tibetan lama, visit the Ladarcha fair in Kaza in July/August to watch the brisk barter and get plenty of local colour.

DO These are also the best months for white-water rafting in the Spiti and Pin rivers. The 36-km route starts at Nadang and ends at Sumdo

STAY Spiti Village Resort, Kaza

EAT The Pahadi version of a thali called *dhaam* or *thukpa* and *thenktuk* noodle soups and momos at bazaar stalls and homestays. Enjoy vegetarian fare and seabuckthorn drinks at Taste of Spiti, and coffee and cake at Sol Café

GO Fly to Bhuntar and drive 230 km